UK Data Service

Pioneers

of Qualitative Research

Paul Thompson

Life story interview with Julie Boekhoff

2007

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Paul Thompson
Interviewed by July Boekhoff
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26: Interviewing Elites (cf 1996 version)

Now, I also got on to various documents in private hands, and partly through that, did a number of interviews, which were the first interviews I ever did. I had no training at all, I didn't know how to do it, and some of them I definitely made a mess of. The worst of all was with Herbert Morrison himself. At that point, he was still an MP, but he'd left the government. He had been Home Secretary, so he'd been really right at the top, but he'd left the government. And he agreed to meet me, he invited me to the House of Commons, and we had tea outside by the river, on the terrace. And I started this interview, and after a while, I said to him, "Did you ever belong to any Marxist Organisation?" And he said, "No! Certainly not!" Well, I knew very well that he had belonged – it's all perfectly well-documented that he belonged to the British Socialist Party for well over a year! (LAUGHS) And, of course, that was absolutely the wrong way to ask a question like that, a difficult issue like that! And you have to let a politician like that know that you're relatively informed. Of course, as soon as he could see that he could walk over me like that - because I just didn't say anything, I let it pass - he completely lost interest in the interview. He got out a large bag of scissors from a kind of handbag he had, and he started cutting his nails and flicking them over the balustrade into the river! (LAUGHS) So that actually put me off oral history for quite a bit. I didn't realise that it was my fault, and that had I known how to ask questions, I might have done a little better.
(p 12)

27: Interviewing for *The Edwardians*

The Social Science Research Council had just been set up with Michael Young, who worked with Peter earlier, as the first Director. It was a very new experiment in Britain. They had a lot of money, and there weren't that number of sociologists around, and so we put in an application to interview 600 older people right across Britain, which turned out to be wildly over-ambitious, we did about 450 in the end. I remember, we sent them a complete transcript of one of our earlier interviews, a man from Great Bentley – a village just down the line from here – where I was living at the time, and my then wife, Thea [Vigne], did the interview… He was called Cliff Hills, and we dedicated *The Edwardians* partly to him. A wonderful man, a really encyclopaedic memory, and a great story teller, and very good on social class – a pungent East Anglian sense of humour about social class. But he could tell you about anything you asked him. So we sent this in, just to show what kind of material you could get. Of course, now you couldn't do that, because they'd only give you about five pages to make

your case! But in those days, there weren't any set rules. So they gave us the money. I don't think we would get that now, it would be really difficult.
(pp 15-16)

28: Eric Hobsbawm and Oral History

It's interesting about Hobsbawm, that although we got this money to help the book [*The Edwardians*] with him, he was never happy about it. When I produced the manuscript, it used the interviews in two different ways. One was in the first bit, which was really a description of what had changed socially, and the part of that on the life cycle – like on childhood and marriage and old age – was largely based on the oral interviews. And then there was a completely separate section, a cross-section of families, starting with the daughter of a duke, down to an unemployed working-class family, just to show the range of social experience, and again, that was wholly from the interviews. And then there was an argumentative bit with virtually no interviews, about the dynamics of change. Then finally there were two interviews about participation in social change, of a conscious and unconscious kind, and we had two women there, deliberately… Anyway, I was really excited by this book, and I still think it's probably the best thing I ever wrote. And Hobsbawm was very unhappy, and he said, "Oh, why don't you cut out that section in the middle, with all that oral history?" and I said, "I'm sorry, but I'm going to keep it in". And I managed to keep it in, thank goodness!

Yes! But he didn't forgive me, because several years later he came to Colchester to give the annual Burrows Co-Operative Society Lecture – he called it "Grass Roots History", which you would have thought would have been supportive of oral history. I was in the audience [with my students], and suddenly he cast his beady eye on me, and for a full five minutes, he launched into a diatribe against oral history and "young men with tape recorders"!

But he didn't name you?

No. But it was obvious who he was talking about! …

The last time I had much real contact with him was at a conference in Italy, which was in [1994], in Arezzo and it was about the massacres by the retreating German army in 1944. We were funded by the Tuscan Region, which had a Communist local government, and they funded this conference on the massacres, and they were interviewing almost local people about their memories. But the memories had come out with unexpected differences.

In some communities [the "provocative" actions of] the Partisans were being blamed for the Germans shooting the people in the communities, you see. Of course, it was political, these were communities which were basically Christian Democrats and dominated by the Church. … Actually, they invited us up, these Christian Democrats, to their little village on a hilltop, it's called Civitella, and they performed a mystery play for us, with various mythical elements, including the priest offering his life to the German soldiers if he would spare the rest of the population. It was amazing, actually! Catholicised the whole thing!

But anyway, in this [conference] final session, one of the people from that community came in when one of the Partisan people was talking, and interrupted and started screaming, and it was a very dramatic situation. And eventually Hobsbawm had to make some comments. The way he put it was, simply that there were two types of history – there was real history based on documents, and then there was mythical history based on memory – and as historians, our task was to work with real history.

I thought that was so crude that I just couldn't believe it! You know, after all these years, he couldn't see it was a bit more complicated than that! Particularly when you consider that, for that kind of event, the only documents of any substance, are on the German side anyway! So how can you do it without doing oral history? …

It's really surprising. I don't know whether, often, he expresses those feelings. But it was a disappointment [for me] anyway, because I have this huge admiration for him. With my Ph.D., of all the people that I read, he was the one that most impressed me, the way every article had something special to say, something really interesting. I thought he was a really great person, and then later it turns round in this very different way.
(pp 16-17)

29: Studying migrant families without compartive statistics

it's incredibly difficult to know whether your material is typical of anything, if it's international, because you can't measure it against anything. There are obviously no figures about transnational families, no figures at all, and even getting information about how well Jamaicans do, in terms of occupations, say, in different countries, the categories are different. Like the Canadian figures are completely different from the US ones. So it's rather sort of odd in that sense, that your material has wonderful reality to it, but you can't relate it very easily to statistical reality or other known social or historical reality.
(p 24)

30: Learning as an outsider to understand

That experience was really very important, and the way that interacting with Jamaicans, including, of course, Elaine herself, in trying to think through the concepts of families. It was one of those most sort of important things that has happened to me, intellectually, in terms of understanding families, for a long time. Because I got to see, more and more, how the assumptions we make, as Europeans, about families, are just cultural assumptions, and that they [Jamaicans] have a different kind of system. In terms of formalities and obligations and so on, their system is much more based on lived experience than ours is, and it works rather well, actually, in the circumstances. But it really took those years to get to see how it was different, and I think it's quite interesting how difficult it is to get through to that. Yet, through oral history and working with people who are in that tradition, you can get to understand something quite differently.
(p 24)

31: Developing theory through fieldwork: family and economy in Scotland

Living the Fishing was a comparative study of four different parts of Scotland. I was trying to look at the way that the economy related to the family, and we started with a rather simple Marxist idea that the form of the fishing created the form of the family. That idea developed in the Shetlands, where we discovered that there was a relatively egalitarian - I mean, in gender terms, by Scottish standards, anyway – and also a remarkable way of bringing up children, by Scottish standards, for they didn't believe in physical punishment at all. And it was an interesting question, "How did this arise?"

Ultimately, part of the explanation, I think, is Scandinavian influence. But our first hypothesis was that it's because with the fishing, the men are going out for short periods, coming back, when they're on the boats they learn to cook and clean, and so they become domestically skilled; the women are temporarily in charge of the farms/crofts while the men are fishing, and so they learn those work skills. So they're dual-skilled households. But we later discovered that in some other parts of Scotland - well, the West, in particular - they had a similar kind of inshore fishing, not so successful I should say, but they had the patriarchal type of families, so [the explanation] didn't really work. And the way it developed, as an interpretation, was that we realised that [the influence] was going the other way round, that the family system in Shetland, which was a historical inheritance from Scandinavian culture – mind you, not all Scandinavia is like that, but Norway, where a lot of these people came from, is – so it's complicated, actually! But they'd not been so moulded by the Christian churches, because they'd been Christianised relatively late. So people continued with this gentleness towards children, and bringing children up to think for themselves, rather than disciplining them to do what they were told to. And that resulted in [adults with] a very adaptable attitude to economic opportunity. So the Shetlanders took on new equipment, changed it, found new markets, got new kinds of boats when they got the chance, and created an extraordinarily successful fishing industry. For [families with] very basic level standard of living, households on islands like Whalsay, which are like working class communities in standard of living, would own boats worth really – in the 1970s – a million pounds.

That's the way it has developed, while in the Western Isles, where they have this patriarchal type of family, the reverse happened. The children were brought up, with quite severe punishment, to follow their elders, who were both elders in the family and of the Church – a very narrow kind of Calvinist Church, where people were taught to believe that their fate had been predetermined, and probably they were going to go to hell, and totally disapproved of sexuality and drinking and all those kind of pleasures of life. The fishing there kept dying out, and needing to be revived by the government.

Then I found the North-East was much like Shetland, with much more independence of thinking, particularly in religion. And Aberdeen was a capitalist port where there were wage-earning fishermen, and they became very downgraded, and they were given free alcohol on

the boats, and there was terrible violence on the boats, and in the families, including murders. So they became stigmatised, a kind of lumpen-proletariat. People didn't want to go on those boats, and actually that kind of fishing really. So all that changed my theoretical understanding. We started with a kind of Gramscian approach, but we turned it round on its head in the end!
(p58-60)

32: Working with life stories in television

I've done quite a lot of work, over the years, as a consultant with television – nearly all of it actually with Steve Humphries, Testimony Films. But I was invited to be the consultant for a BBC2 series called *The Nineties*, which was about people aged over 90. It was done in the 1990s, 1992-3, and the producer was Annie Paul, an absolutely brilliant person, really admirable producer. She has a very strong concept of what will work on television, and how to get there, but at the same time she's a really nice human being and treats the people she's interviewing really well, and that's something that doesn't always happen with television. Of course, Steve takes huge trouble with his people, but a lot of the standard producers don't.

It was a very exciting experience, because I was brought in just at the stage when they started, and they were trying to formulate what the programmes would be about. They had issued trailers - well, information about this all round the country, and people were writing in and offering to be interviewed, sending letters, so we got a lot of that stuff. And then they had just begun audio interviews with people to try them out. So we were talking about these people, and how they could make programmes.

Actually the whole thing evolved. It wasn't that we sat down at the beginning to say we had, you know, "These six programmes", but the first one or two were of obvious, like there were women talking about marriage - well, and men. There were always more women than men in these programmes because, for one thing, [in that age group] there's about five women alive to every man. But there was another programme on women who didn't marry. Those were obvious subjects. Then we had one on health, … but by the end it became rather difficult.

We wanted one on migrants, but we couldn't get a spectrum of migrants, there just weren't enough black migrants available. There were women Jewish migrants, yes, but if you wanted the typical West Indian coming to Britain in the fifties, which would have been the obvious thing to have, they just haven't survived. So the last programme I think Annie decided to do on races and race, partly because there was this one black man involved, and there wasn't another obvious way of using him!

But then, you see, so that was the first stage, you've got this audio material and notes on that coming in, and notes by the researchers on visiting the interviewees, and then you get the preliminary audio-visual [material] to look at, which is much more crucial of course, and sitting and talking, discussing that. Then finally you get to the rough cut, which is slightly

longer than the real transmission, when you really have to decide whether it works or not, and if it doesn't seem to work, what to do about it.

That was just fascinating because in a way it's more drastic. So for instance, in the programme we had on health, Annie had put a sequence with one of the first professional social psychiatric workers. And it just had to go, because she didn't gel with the other people. And by that point, the book [of the series] which I edited, was already in the press, so we had people who are in the book who weren't in the programmes, and vice-versa! There were people in the programmes who weren't in the book! But I didn't realise that it happened that way. The final programme was only completed a few days before it went out, while the book was already available in the shops.

But that brought home to me, really powerfully, how the audio-visual presence is different from the purely oral on the one hand, or the printed on the other. And it's a work of art using that [audio-visual] material, just as it is using printed extracts from interviews. It does profoundly affect how you shape material and how you use it. I found that just fascinating.

There's one thing I did manage to get them to do, which I was very pleased about. When I arrived, they were thinking of using these people like museum exhibits so that they were just talking about their past. I said, "Let's have them now as well", and that really worked very well. And so you had the woman who writes poetry, reading one of her poems out while pouring a grey cup of tea. And then there was a man who still rides his bike, setting out on his bike. I think that made quite a lot of difference. So that's one of the things, I really felt was worthwhile, and I'm tremendously proud of that.
(pp 67-8)

33: Archiving Qualidata and *Pioneering Social Reseaarch*

Qualidata came out of the archival experience of the National Life Story Collection. I realised that, by that point, we were beginning to do reasonably well with oral history, but there were lots of other rather similar interviews done by sociologists and anthropologists, which weren't being archived at all. And I eventually wrote a paper, I think maybe Asa Briggs jointly signed it, I can't remember whether he wrote a little note at the beginning, but anyway, it had the stamp of his authority. We were given a little bit of money by the Research Council to survey what was happening, and we found that only about 20 per cent of the material [recorded] was being archived at all, and most of that was in insecure archives. Then we were able to produce some figures saying, it would cost over a million pounds to reproduce this kind of material, and it's a scandalous waste of national resources just to let it disappear like that. And there were sort of hints made that we might raise this as a Parliamentary Question, very subtly!

I think that somebody got interested at the Research Council, because I suddenly got a phone call from them saying, "You may find this surprising, but we want you to apply with this idea

for this particular initiative we're making" - it didn't appear to be anything to do with what we wanted to do, but they really led us into it. So it then got set up. I was actually somewhat upset, in a sense, because it dragged me back to administrative work. I hadn't really wanted to run this show, and I don't think I ran it all that well, because I'd no experience of archiving. But fortunately, I got Louise Corti, we appointed her - who's Brenda's daughter actually, but that wasn't why she was appointed! But she's very dynamic, very systematic and she really goes for it, and she made it work. She took it as her own and she really made it work.

It's brought a big change in the whole system [of funded social research], so that, now, people who are applying for research money here, have to discuss whether they're going to archive the material or not, and they're expected, in many cases, to do that afterwards. And there's a really big collection developing at the Data Archive. And as far as I know, we've taken the lead in this country in that way. I think it's probably the most advanced system anywhere, in that way.

So I worked for that for about another five years, and as part of that I started interviewing the leading researchers that we were archiving, many famous people, including Peter Townsend – that's about the longest interview I've ever done, 17 recorded hours! And the oldest person I've ever interviewed, Raymond Firth, was 99 when I interviewed him. Very clear-minded, fantastic man!
(pp 72-3)